

CORE FORMULA

Purpose -> context -> ask -> reply path -> deadline or next step. -> Minimum viable move: "Quick ask: can you approve the revised copy? Only the headline changed. Reply approve or edit by Thursday noon; I'll handle the update." -> Full field version: "Decision needed. We have two workable options. Choose A or B. A/B is enough. By 3 pm so I can brief the team." -> Field rule: if the reader can grasp the job of the message, why it matters, and how to respond without scrolling, you are close.

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

State the purpose, give one context line, make one clear ask, and add an easy reply path.

BEST FOR

- Email requests, Slack or Teams updates, and calendar follow-ups
- Networking messages, introductions and reminders
- Lightweight decisions and manager updates
- Customer-service replies and team handoffs
- Messages the recipient will read on a phone, between meetings, or inside a crowded thread
- Making a response easier - not hiding complexity

PHRASE BANK

Quick asks & openers · Short orienting one-liners

- "Quick ask: can you approve the revised headline by 2 pm?"
- "Quick question on timing: hold for your review, or move ahead with version B?"
- "Quick check: is the \$8k-\$10k range still right?"
- "Simple version: I can do Saturday at 10 or Sunday at 3."
- "Bottom line up top: we're on track; one approval needed."
- "One screen: what changed, what I need, and by when."
- "Short version first, detail below if it's useful."

Work requests & updates · Professional / meeting / client

- "Quick ask: can you confirm whether option A is acceptable? It keeps the launch date unchanged. A yes/no by 2 pm is enough."
- "Update in one screen: the vendor confirmed Friday delivery. No action needed from you unless the timing creates a problem."
- "Status: on track. Action needed: approve the supplier change by Friday 2 pm."
- "Can you confirm whether the draft can ship today? Reply yes, hold, or edit."
- "Bottom line: we're on track, but the budget change needs your call - approve the extra \$900, or reduce scope."
- "Following up on the proposal: is the budget range still right? I'll adjust from your reply."
- "Two workable options, one decision: choose A or B and I'll run with it."
- "Handover in one screen: here's the state, the open item, and who owns it next."

Decisions & reply paths · The exact ask and how to answer

- "Decision needed by 3 pm: A keep Friday launch with reduced scope, or B move to Tuesday with full scope. Reply A or B."
- "A one-word reply is enough: approve, edit, or hold."
- "Reply A to keep Friday launch, or B to move to Tuesday."
- "A yes/no reply is enough; I'll handle the next step."
- "My recommendation is version B because it protects Friday launch - reply B or hold by 4 pm."

- "Here's the exact ask: sign off the headline change, nothing else."
- "Pick whichever is easier; if neither works, we can skip this round."

Context & warmth lines · Just enough context, kept human

- "The only context you need is that the deadline moved from Tuesday to Friday."
- "I know this is a sensitive one, so I want to keep the ask clear rather than bury it."
- "Good to meet you yesterday - sending the article I mentioned. No reply needed."
- "No reply needed; it just matched your point about onboarding."
- "I put the detail below the line so the decision stays visible first."
- "No rush on this - I just wanted the ask to be easy to find."
- "Thanks for turning this around under pressure; here's the one thing left to decide."

Autonomy & recovery · Protect choice; fix a message that missed

- "No pressure if this isn't the right week; a quick no is helpful too."
- "No is a fine answer."
- "I made that too dense - the actual ask is this..."
- "I compressed that too much; the missing context is..."
- "Let me separate the decision from the detail."
- "I buried the ask. What I need is your approval on the revised copy."
- "That came across abrupt - I was aiming for clarity, not pressure."
- "I should have made the reply path clearer: A, B, or hold are all fine."

Escalation & pressure · High-stakes decisions kept clear

- "Decision needed: pause the launch, or proceed with known risk. My recommendation is pause - detail below."
- "I'll keep this short: we need a decision on the client response by 4 pm."
- "Separating decision from detail - the decision is approve, edit, or hold."
- "No pressure to decide from this message alone; this is just the orientation. I can send the full rationale or talk it through."
- "One call to make now, three things you can read later if you want them."
- "This needs a real decision, not a quick yes - here's the choice and the trade-off."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: "Hi, I had a few thoughts after our call and wanted to run them by you - there are a number of moving parts..." The ask is buried and the reader has to infer the action.

Better: "I have one decision for you: keep the launch date, or reduce scope? Context below." The job is visible, but the reply path could be easier.

Best: "Decision by 3 pm: A keep Friday launch with reduced scope, or B move to Tuesday with full scope. Reply A or B; I'll update the plan." The reader can act from one screen.

2. Weak: "Following up on the attached." The reader has no idea what response is wanted.

Better: "Following up on the attached proposal - can you confirm the budget range is still right?" The ask is present but the effort is open-ended.

Best: "Quick check: is the \$8k-\$10k range still right? A yes/no is enough; I'll adjust the proposal." One screen, one easy reply.

DECISION TREE

If The message has no clear job yet

Decide the job - inform, ask, decide, invite, hand over - before you write a word.

If The job is inform-only

Say so early so no one hunts for a hidden ask.

"No action needed unless the timing creates a problem."

If The job is a decision

State the decision, the options and the deadline together.

"Decision by 3 pm: A or B. Reply A or B."

If The job is a request

State the exact action and hand them an easy reply path.

"Can you approve the headline? A yes/no is enough."

If Necessary detail won't fit one screen

Write a one-screen summary and put the rest below, linked or attached.

"Detail below if useful."

If The content is sensitive or the reader might feel pressured

Add a care line and protect their autonomy instead of over-compressing.

"No is a fine answer - no pressure if the timing doesn't work."

SCENARIOS

Manager update

Lead with status and whether action is needed, then the deadline. — "Status: on track. Action needed: approve the supplier change by Friday 2 pm."

Client email

Lead with the useful answer, keep context minimal, park fuller rationale below a divider. — "Short answer: yes, we can hit Friday. Detail below if useful."

Networking follow-up

Make the purpose and the no-pressure tone visible up front. — "Good to meet you - sending the article I mentioned. No reply needed."

Slack or Teams request

Use a compact ask plus a ready-made reply option. — "Can the draft ship today? Reply yes, hold, or edit."

Scheduling

Offer two clear choices and an exit ramp. — "Tuesday 10 or Thursday 2? If neither works, I can send notes instead."

Escalation or delicate issue

Separate the decision from the detail; add warmth before you compress. — "I know this is sensitive, so I'll keep the ask clear: pause, or proceed with known risk. My recommendation is pause."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- The issue needs substantial evidence, legal or clinical detail, or careful documentation
- The moment calls for emotional repair or a consent-sensitive decision
- The other person has asked for depth, or brevity would feel dismissive given the power dynamic
- A short message would leave them feeling handled rather than heard
- Safety, grief, serious conflict or a major money decision is in play - slow down instead
- Physical safety or an immediate emergency takes priority

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Buried-ask rewrite

Take a 200-word email you sent recently and rewrite it as five lines: purpose, context, ask, reply path, deadline. Notice how much was throat-clearing.

Day 2 — Phone-width test

View a real draft at phone width. If the ask isn't visible without scrolling, move it up or shorten the context until it is.

Day 3 — Reply-path test

On three drafts, add one line that tells the recipient exactly how to respond: yes/no, A/B, approve/edit/hold, or one sentence of feedback.

Day 4 — Warmth check

Find a message that involves effort, inconvenience, disappointment, uncertainty or a power imbalance, and add one relational line before the ask.

Day 5 — Detail parking

Take a long message and move all background below a divider labelled "Detail if useful", keeping the decision and reply path above it.

Day 6 — Five-minute repetition

Rewrite three old messages as one-screen messages. For each, mark what changed: purpose, context, ask, reply path, or deadline.

Day 7 — Live send

Send one genuine one-screen message today. Note how fast the reply came and whether they answered the intended question without a follow-up.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Can the reader identify the message job in the first line?
- Is the ask visible without scrolling?
- Is there enough context for a safe, informed response?
- Is the reply path easy - yes/no, A/B, approve/edit/hold, or one sentence?
- Is any deadline real, fair and relevant - not manufactured?
- If it's sensitive, have I added care instead of just shortening - and would I be happy to receive this on a busy day?